fear regarding the physical danger of stepping out in the open due to shelling and air strikes.

This is when you really look to your government for support and extrication. And indeed, this is when its entire foreign policy apparatus swings into action as it did through Operation Ganga. It did so by facilitating transport, including trains and buses. It intervened at the highest levels in Russia and Ukraine to ensure ceasing of fire for safe passage. It engaged the border authorities to enable border crossing. And in extreme cases, such as in the city of Sumy, its representatives even traversed conflict zones to ensure the necessary logistics for your safety. Once you were out of Ukraine, it worked with neighbouring governments in Romania, Poland, Hungary and Slovakia to establish transit camps, utilize air fields and organize the flights required for a return home. Reflect for a moment on the efforts, interventions and relationships at various levels, starting from the very top, that were involved to make all of this happen.

Revisit then Kabul on 15 August 2021. Imagine that, for whatever reason, you found yourself stranded when the Taliban suddenly took over the city. Apart from navigating a city now controlled by Taliban checkpoints, you could well ask how difficult going home could be. Well, a great effort had to be made by the Indian government. It was as challenging as combining access to a secured American airbase that was on edge, surrounded by desperate Afghans and suspicious Taliban; using Tajik rear support for quick response; accessing Iranian airspace at short notice; and quietly utilizing Gulf facilitation! Some others were beneficiaries of seats in flights run by the United States of America (US), the United Kingdom (UK), the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and France that were delicately negotiated. This might seem like exceptionally complicated logistics. But it was more than that: behind it were years of relationships that really delivered at a time of need. Equally important is that this represented the efficacy of a flexible and pragmatic Indian policy of multiple engagements.

The Operation Devi Shakti flights from Kabul may have been extraordinarily stressful, but they were still manageable at short notice. In terms of numbers involved, India’s response to the demands generated by the Covid pandemic was much bigger. The Vande Bharat Mission, which brought back millions of Indians from multiple countries by air, sea and land, is perhaps the largest recorded evacuation exercise in history. The movement of people was only the tip of the iceberg. Driving it was a